

MATERIAL GUIDE¹

Reference Code: UA00.07 [Butler University Audio and Audiovisual Materials, 1963-2021](#)

Date(s) of Creation:

Creator(s): Butler University

Immediate Source of Acquisition: Butler University; Special Collections, Rare Books, and University Archives at Butler University; The Vivian W. Delbrook Visiting Writers Series, various speakers.

Accession Number: UA00.07

Forms of Material: Audiocassettes, audiotapes, audiovisual materials, magnetic tapes, videodiscs

Extent: 10 banker boxes (16.25" x 13" x 10.5")

Languages and Scripts:

Conditions Governing Access: Collection is open for research.

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Repository: Special Collections, Rare Books, and University Archives, Irwin Library, Butler University, 4600 Sunset Avenue, Indianapolis, Indiana 46208-3485.

Citation: [Item Title or Description], [Date], Box [Number], Folder [Number], [Folder Title], Butler University Audio and Audiovisual Materials (UA00.07), Special Collections, Rare Books, and University Archives, Irwin Library, Butler University.

¹ The access to the public repository (once created) is yet to be confirmed. During the May 2026 meeting between the English Dept. and our specialists from Irwin Library, we discussed potentially opening access to students for research based on revisions to our Visiting Writers Series contracts given to authors.

VWS Collection Documentation | May 2024 – May 2026

Eli(se) Davidson | Butler '26 | Anthropology & English LTCC

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Contacts.....	2
TL; DR Synopsis of Goals	3
Helpful Figures.....	3
This Document Key	4
Physical Media Reference	4
Resources & Learning Tools.....	4
Defining the Collection	5
Physical Media	5
Digital Media & Current Repository.....	5
How to Download & Obsidian	6
How to Use the Temporary Repository.....	6
Continuing Digitizing Efforts.....	8
INSTRUCTIONS TO RECORD:	10

INSTRUCTIONS TO (BASIC) RESTORE:	11
INSTRUCTIONS TO GENERATE TRANSCRIPTION:	13
Past Conflicts	14

TL; DR Synopsis of Goals

English Department Initiatives:

- Revise the **Consent Forms** for Visiting Authors to gather their approval for Archival Educational Use
 - NOTE: Our staff must determine if this collection will be available at a **university-wide** or **Public Domain level**.
 - **Examples of other institutional visiting author archives:**
 - **Level 1: Basic Audio-Visual Publication w/o Repository or Index**
 - Eastern Washington University on [YouTube](#)
 - **PRO:** Many overlapping visiting authors = potentially easier adjustments to past contracts.
 - **CON:** YouTube as host is very poor for organizing collection relationality for research.
 - **Level 2: Audio-Visual Publication w/o Repository w/ Index**
 - **ArchivesSpace - Finding Aid**
 - **Level 3: Hosted Public Collection w/ Repository**
 - [University of East Anglia Norwich](#), The British Archive for Contemporary Writing on [CollectionsIndex+ Collections Online](#)
 - **PRO:** Provides a “how to use our archive collections” = framework for public access.
 - Optimizes a relational hierarchy.
 - **CON:** Combined visiting writers' series with special collections.
 - Lack of audio-visual files.



Helpful Figures

This Document Key

- **Green** = Person of Interest
- **Blue** = Notes & Guide for Future Student Workers
- **Purple** = Digital Paths

Physical Media Reference

[Physical Inventory in Banker Boxes, Organized by Author Last Name A to Z](#)

Type of Media	Total Counts / Box	Arrangement
Cassettes Note: Boxes of cassettes could have a third layer but is ill-advised due to the weight of the box!	118 total 59 per layer 2 layers	22 vertical (T-B) 3 columns facing L-R with 5 cassettes in each.
VHS	44 total 22 per layer 2 layers	14 vertical (T-B) 2 columns facing L-R with 4 VHS in both.
DVD	We have about 195 DVDs in the collection.	Good luck! Many of these are duplicates.

Resources & Learning Tools

Obsidian - Download

- [Roadmap](#)
- [Changelog](#)
- [Developer Docs](#)

The Community:

- [Discord](#)
- [GitHub](#)

Archival Practices & the VWS Collection

Council on Library & Information Resources (CLIR)

- [Magnetic Tape Storage and Handling](#)

Library of Congress (LOC) - Sustainability of Digital Formats

- [Sound >> Quality and Functionality Factors](#)

International Association of Sound and Audiovisual Archives (IASA)

- TC-03 [The Safeguarding of the Audiovisual Heritage](#)
- TC-05 [Handling and Storage of Audio and Video Carriers](#)

Federal Agencies Digital Guidelines Initiative (FADGI)

- [Creating and Archiving Born Digital Video](#)
- Analog-to-Digital Convertors (ADCs)
 - [Low Cost](#)

- High-Level
- Metadata of WEBVTT Files

Defining the Collection

Physical Media

Stored in ten banker boxes (inc. one box of JJW) found in the Digital Lab in Irwin Library, supervised by our **Digital Scholarship Associate, Julian Cabiya**.

- 1) Each box has two labels defining the contents:
 - a) The front label reads with the box # (the star prefix means the entire box has been digitized) and “VWS: type of media.”
 - b) The top label reads the same as above, AND the *processed* and *digitized* dates (“YYYY-MM-DD”) of the digital media.
- 2) Each box is organized alphabetically by the author's last name:
 - a) If there are multiple authors on one recording, opt for the first last name beginning A to Z.
 - b) If there are multiple types of media within the same container, the alike type (i.e., Cassettes) will be grouped from A to Z, then begin again with the other type.
 - i) As of May 2026, there are two boxes in the VWS collection with multiple types of media: Box01 and Box09. The JJW Collection box also features an assortment of media types.

Future workers should optimize the collection’s storage by developing a physical schema to organize alike types. This should be done together with the downsizing of the collection; our main question being: Do we need to maintain copied (duplicated) physical media, considering best archival practices?

Moreover, should this reorganization be based upon the English Department’s handling of VWS seasons, paying attention to academic years? This may look something like:

- a. **Title:** Box01
- b. **Seasons:** Fall 1980 – Spring 1988
- c. **Content:** VHS

The **JJW Collection** should be addressed as a separate collection and repository in the future, but as of May 2026, it is hosted in the same location as the VWS in **Obsidian**.

Digital Media & Current Repository

Due to the University undergoing digital archive changes, the VWS Collection was made using the open-source platform **Obsidian** to render the metadata and descriptive sets

pertaining to the digitized audio/visual file produced from each physical media. It significantly aided processes of determining duplicated media, as it acts as a relational database allowing us to proactively connect visiting authors to their respective visits (some multiple), readings, lectures, interviews and/or Q&As. [It is recommended that any future work reads the documentation for Obsidian to become more familiar with the program's punctuation.](#)

The choice of **Obsidian** was thanks to its highly customizable markdown files that can [easily be converted to maintain all metadata in future repositories](#). Allison O'Keeffe, and Kyle Stearns, would be individuals to work with to determine the next steps. During the May 2026 meeting with the people noted in the [contacts](#) section, it was determined that the repository should be addressed with three stages of public intent:

1)

How to Download & Obsidian

Future workers can access the May 2026 version of Obsidian **LOCALLY** (in the Digital Scholarship Lab at the AV Computer) at the following path: [D:\VWS Digital Media\2026o6-VWS_Obsidian](#). **DO NOT OPEN OBSIDIAN WITH THIS PATH! IT WILL BREAK THE FILES!**

- 1) Using ROBOCOPY and the instructions found [here](#), copy the folder "2026o6-VWS_Obsidian" to a new folder created at the following path:
[C:\Users\ "NAME" \Documents\OBSIDIANBACKUP"YYYY-MM-DD"](#)
 - a. **WHY?** This helps us maintain a backup of the original repository created by Eli(se) on this computer, while letting future workers add to the digitization initiative. Saving markdown files to C:\ takes less than a half-GB and is the only way Obsidian will run without conflict or corruption!
- 2) Download Obsidian from <https://obsidian.md/>
- 3) Select "Open Folder as Vault" and click on the folder you created!
- 4) Obsidian will then render the repository allowing you to view the media files attached to digitized media, providing a foundation to view the collection.

How to Use the Temporary Repository

"999 ASSETS" is where you will begin in the vault. It acts as a homepage. On the left-hand side is the explorer of this **vault**. This is how you access the various markdown files.

- 1) The search function on the top right corner allows you to query from many components.
 - a. **Path:** queries based on the paths of files across the entire vault. You can search for year, date, content, and author thanks to the naming schema!

- i. Best used to compare file names between media and transcriptions.
- b. **File:** queries based on file strings.
 - i. Best used to open individual media files. Ctrl+O is the hotkey.
- c. **Line:()** queries from all text in the vault; pulls individual lines in each file.
THIS IS VERY SLOW!
 - i. There are solutions to this issue in the Obsidian Community (i.e., Discord, Reddit, GitHub), but due to the temporary nature of this repository, Eli(se) did not commit to resolving the issues.
 - ii. **However**, as this is an English-based collection, Eli(se) suggests that the future goals align with implementation of a by-line search function to aid in research and relationality.
 - 1. The transcription files were created with this in mind.
- **“999 ASSETS/_Templates”** contains the templates needed to create or add:
 - A new visiting author (**“T-Author”**)
 - A new media file with metadata (**“T-Import”**)
 - Auto-type the transcript property (**“ADD Transcript Prop”**)
 - Add the transcript callout to the media page (**“Add Transcript Callout”**)
 - Add the Mentions callout to the media page (**“Add Mentions”**)
 - Add the metadata to a download WebVTT file (**“Add Transcript Meta”**)
- **“Authors”** contains individual pages for each visiting author of the series, as well as a **Dataview** (live index & query engine) listing with each media file per author.
 - Metadata properties are as follows:
 - Auto filled on creation of a new note with name **LAST, FIRST**
 - Name (last, first); First; Last; Type (“Author”); Modified
 - **Needs custom input!**
 - Alive (toggle); Birth (date); Death (date); Nationality; Discipline
- **“Box Inventory”** contains **Bases** generated by a native Obsidian query. Each banker box has a respective **Base** on Obsidian AND on the Microsoft Excel Spreadsheet – THESE MUST BE MANUALLY UPDATED.² It serves as a double-checking protocol due to the amount of physical and digital material.
- **“Media”** contains indexed files of digitized AV media. Each file contains the metadata shown in the MAP (*below*) and a very basic template (**“T-Import”**).
 - These files become rendered in the **“Box Inventory”** bases, allowing us to view the respective container contents alongside current digitization.

² The Excel Spreadsheets must only be updated with the most accurate information. It is, ultimately, the index for the VWS collection and can be accessed by anyone following or shared with the SharePoint, Butler University Libraries-Special Collections, (Projects) VWS Digital Media.

- At the bottom of each file (from the template) is a heading, **Related Visits**. Below is a **dataview query** that has been auto generated for each media file, and therefore, may be broken due to spelling errors.
 - This should be fixed by the future worker as it helps quickly identify other visits by the same author (i.e., reading vs. Q&A) and the current digital status.
- **ISSUE:** There may be multiple for one author's visit, denoted by the trailing -1 /-2 /-3. This should be addressed by the future worker, as we only need one copy of each recording in the collection itself.
 - There should still be multiple backups of our digitization efforts.
- **“Transcripts”** contains auto-generated transcriptions of each media file and their respective audio-visual attachments. These were generated as WebVTT files and converted into markdown, hence the timecodes above brief sections of text—this was done to preemptively provide potential web styles required for an institutional repository.
 - Before moving files to the **vault**, the downloaded WebVTT should be renamed to match the same file name as the respective “Media” file, plus the suffix “-en-US,” and replace “.webvtt” with “.md” **Explicit instructions are provided later in this document!**
 - Transcriptions have five metadata properties added to the now markdown file with the template **“ADD Transcript Meta”**
 - File-Name, Video, tags, Revised, Reviewed
 - The “File-Name” and “Video” must be INPUT MANUALLY.

Continuing Digitizing Efforts

Using the **TASCAM 202MKVII** located in the **Digital Lab** in **Irwin Library** at the **audiovisual station**, the future student worker will be able to complete the digitization process. There are about 150+ remaining cassettes. If the next student work were to complete the collection initiative themselves as Eli(se) has done, it is estimated to take around ~350hrs.

MAP (Metadata Approach)

Properties	Format	Type	Notes
Digital	n/a	Checkbox	Could you watch it right now through SharePoint?
Inventory	Box #	Text	These are subject to change. Maintain a reference point for the previous location/box # to aid in any

			future conflicts or confusion.
Author	Last, First	Hyperlink	Last and First names are in separate properties in author pages to sort alphabetically.
Program	VWS, JJW, etc.	Text	The hosting program or organization.
Accompanied	Last, First	Hyperlink	Based on whether two or more authors presented together in a visit.
Shared	S	Text	DIFF. THAN ACCOMPANIED; Based on the recording media and whether it is shared with multiple authors.
Date	YYYY-MM-DD	Date	If exact date is unknown, use YYYY-MM or YYYY
Title (optional)	“ “	Text	If the program has a title or keynote discussion, etc.
Content	[Reading, Q&A, etc.]	List	What is contained in the recording; in the end, all READING and Q&A will be stored as separate files.
Location	Johnson Room, etc.	Text	Where the visit took place.
Version	Master/Copy		No longer in use as the schema and MAP approach depreciated the need for copy defining. Additionally, the use of “Master” for the original copy should be removed from this collection’s scope entirely.
Media	[VHS, etc]	List	Defines the type of media with Video8 cassettes having a sub-level for quick recognition.
PRI-Notes	“ “	Text	These are PRIOR notes left by fellow archivists working with this collection
ED-Notes	“ “	Text	My own notes about the media.
File-Name	date content initial - author	Hyperlink	Describes the media file name for digital access. EX: 19940418R-Author

Duration	00:00:00	Text	
File Size	MB/GB/KB	Text	
Transcription	"File-Name"-en-US.md	Hyperlink	Describes the transcription string for digital access.
TempComp	n/a	Checkbox	Additional verification that digitization efforts are completed for individual media files.

INSTRUCTIONS TO RECORD:

- 1) Power on the computer and TASCAM. Unplug any USB attachments, such as headphones, as they will override the recording process.
- 2) Open Adobe Audition.
 - a. Right-click on the empty space underneath "Files" in the top left corner.
 - b. Create a new Audio File – it is best to name the track using the Obsidian file name to avoid confusion (*see MAP, above*).
- 3) Before loading the cassette tape, inspect any damage or mold.
 - a. NOTE: As of May 2026, there have not been any afflictions to the collection.
- 4) Load cassette into the TASCAM tape deck.
- 5) Check that the REC LEVEL is set between three and four. Altering this volume WILL impact the volume of the recording on Audition. Due to the nature of this collection and based on prior restoration efforts, it is best to KEEP THIS NOB AT THREE/FOUR.
- 6) Adjust the PHONES volume nob to the fourth notch. Altering this volume will NOT impact the volume of the recording on Audition.
- 7) Press PLAY on the TASCAM. Once you hear feedback, STOP the tape. REW to 00:00.
- 8) Back on Audition, press the red circle to begin RECORDING.
- 9) Then, on the TASCAM, press PLAY once more.
- 10) The Editor Pane on Audition should now respectively display the waveforms being recorded off the cassette tape.
 - a. **OPTIONAL:** Eli(se) found it beneficial to go to "View" on the top bar and select "Show Spectral Frequency Display" as it helps identify the author's voice/pitch.
- 11) When the tape reaches the end of one side, the TASCAM will auto-stop.
- 12) Press the 'M' key while on Audition to make a marker at that time on the editor pane.
 - a. Then, press the red circle to STOP RECORDING.
- 13) Press the EJECT button on the TASCAM. Turn the tape over in the deck, examining any defects that may have occurred in the last run, and load cassette to record side B.
- 14) Press PLAY on the TASCAM.

- a. Repeat steps 7-11.
- 15) If you are NOT restoring/editing the audio, you may now trim the audio file based upon the waveform display.
- 16) Press “File” on the top bar to save the audio file to “Save As”
 - a. Rename “File Name:” to proper media file schema (*see MAP, above*)
 - b. Set the “Location:” to D:\VWS Digital Media\202604-onwards_digitization
 - c. Set the “Format:” to MP3 Audio (*.mp3)
 - d. Save.

INSTRUCTIONS TO (BASIC) RESTORE:

NOTE: This is in by no means a complete and comprehensive guide. Much of the “restoration” done thus far on digitized material has been extremely basic, and future workers are encouraged to engage with more resources on “how to.”

If you are continuing from the recording process, DO NOT continue past Step 15 from above. Instead, skip to Step 20 below.

- 17) Plug in a pair of USB headphones to the computer. This will prevent you from recording the TASCAMs audio but allows you to hear Audition.
- 18) Set the **computer volume to about halfway**. This can be adjusted for personal preference and hearing but maintain a **range between 40-60%** for accuracy.
- 19) Open Adobe Audition.
 - a. Right-click on the empty space underneath “Files” in the top left corner.
 - b. Press “Open” and locate the audio file in D:\VWS Digital Media\202604-onwards_digitization
- 20) Go to “View” on the top bar and select “Show Spectral Frequency Display”
 - a. This will open a window underneath the waveforms. It helps in identifying the background noise and the author’s pitch.
- 21) Look to the right of the waveform window.
 - a. Determine whether the peaks are within the **range of 6-9 decibels**. And that the broadband waveforms are primarily **between 9-15 decibels**.
 - i. **IF NOT:** Use the key bind **Ctrl+A** to select the entire audio file.
 - 1. Use the popout window with a small circle and line (volume knob) next to the “+0 dB” to adjust volume to normalized ranges.
 - ii. There may be moments of applause near the **beginning** and **ending** of the audio that **exceed the volume threshold**. These need to be **MANUALLY adjusted**.
 - iii. Additionally, this threshold experiences an err while recording in the tape deck – this results in an often-small red line found on the axis.

1. These can be hard to spot, but disastrous when attempting to restore the file. **TAKE YOUR TIME TO OVERLOOK THE ENTIRE FILE AND CAREFULLY REMOVE THESE SEGMENTS BEFORE CONTINUING.**

22) With the volume adjusted, now you can remove any excess noise from the legacy materials – this typically includes a slight hum and high-pitched hiss.

- a. The “Spectral Frequency Display” can identify where this noise is most isolated in the record (i.e., without voices).
 - i. Use the display to select a segment of audio that displays the noise frequencies without voices.
 - ii. Use the key bind **Shift+P** to “Capture the Noise Print”
- b. Go to “Effects” on the top bar and select “Noise Reduction / Restoration,” then “Noise Reduction (process). This can also be accessed through the key bind **Ctrl+Shift+P**.
 - i. If the “Capture the Noise Print” did not work, you will see a cautionary box in the window stating that the print is undefined.
- c. Begin to toggle the green (threshold) and yellow (high) spectrums using the blue axis line at 70 dB, adding **at maximum 5 points to adjust the volume of the noise floor** in respect to the red (low) spectrum Hz frequency.
 - i. NOTE: Again, not very technical, but it can be done by ear and takes time to balance.
 1. Use the “Output Noise Only” to hear ONLY what you are reducing/removing from the audio file.
 - a. Attempt to remove all traces of audible oration; you only want the background noise to be reduced.
 2. Use the green power button in the bottom left corner to hear what it would sound like to apply the reduce/remove to the entire file – this is how you check your work.
 - ii. Press “Apply” when satisfied.
 1. NOTE: It may not be perfect, but you’re attempting to remove the irritating hiss that makes replay nearly unbearable!

23) If there are still issues with the results, you can explore the “Effects” tab on top.

- a. NOTE: Eli(se) does not have enough knowledge to create proper documentation for these steps. However, there are many recent YouTube videos that showcase how to restore the pitch and/or frequencies tones.
- b. Recommended features:
 - i. “Parametric Equalizer” can shape the tone of audio across the frequency spectrum.
 1. Adjusting the **3rd Band to a Q-width of 16** was beneficial for Eli(se) in various cases of older cassettes (1980-1996)

2. Bringing the **HP Band to a frequency range of 24Hz to 34Hz** helps to remove the echo found in almost all recordings.
 3. Bringing the **Low Band down to about -60 dB** helps to remove the bass-y echo from Clowes Memorial Hall.
 4. Bringing the **High Band down to about -15 dB** helps to remove the slight ring created from tape feedback, particularly present in recordings from the Reilly Room.
 - a. Use the green power button in the bottom left corner to hear what it would sound like to apply the changes to the entire file – this is how you check your work.
 - ii. “Time and Pitch” > “Manual Pitch Correction (process)” is for individual pitch correction. Thus far, about 5 media files have been identified with issues of pitch, assumed to be due to the number of voices in recording.
 1. **This is something that needs to be addressed in the future.**
- 24) Press “File” on the top bar to save the audio file to “Save As”
- a. Rename “File Name:” to proper media file schema (*see MAP, above*)
 - b. Set the “Location:” to **D:\VWS Digital Media\202604-onwards_digitization**
 - c. Set the “Format:” to MP3 Audio (*.mp3)
 - d. Save.

INSTRUCTIONS TO GENERATE TRANSCRIPTION:

Note: Eli(se) originally transcribed the audio-visual files in real time as they were being digitized. To respect the student-worker's responsibilities and opt for efficiency, all future transcriptions will be completed with website anytranscribe.com.

- 1) On anytranscribe.com, upload the digitized media with “Click to Upload Audio/Video.”
- 2) Press TRANSCRIBE. While it processes, open Obsidian to the working media file.
 - a. The website lists the duration and size of the file; double-check that this is accurate to what you just digitized. Eli(se) found it helpful to pull this info into the respective media file properties.
- 3) While in the transcript property, use the key bind **Ctrl-Q** to paste the **“ADD Transcript Prop”** (this automatically adds the “-en-US” suffix to denote that it is a transcript)
 - a. Copy the file string now in the property. DO NOT include the “[[or]]”
- 4) Once the file has finished transcribing, press EXPORT.
- 5) Select EXPORT as VTT. The file will download as **“transcript.vtt”**
- 6) In the top right corner of Explorer, open the recent **“Downloads”**
 - a. Click on the open folder to the right when hovering over **“transcript.vtt”**

- 7) Rename the file by pasting your copied file string, **changing the file type from .vtt to .md with MANUAL INPUT**
- 8) Move the file from the “Downloads” folder to “Transcripts” located in the vault.
- 9) Navigate back to Obsidian.
 - a. The backlink that you added to the transcription property should now be dark purple, signaling that there is a file attached to the path.
 - b. Open the Transcription file.
- 10) At the top of the file, use the key bind **Ctrl+N** to insert “ADD Transcript Meta” (this automatically adds the five properties associated with the transcript template)
 - a. **File-Name and Video must be INPUT MANUALLY** with the respective media file and audio-visual file. The audio-visual link will be greyed out as the digitized files are not located in the vault—**HOWEVER. Please keep these hyperlinks accurate for future reference.**
- 11) Transcript files can be revised and reviewed before publication.

Past Conflicts

As of April 2026, Julian Cabiya and Eli(se) Davidson discovered various syncing issues between **OneDrive, SharePoint, and Teams** that ultimately corrupted some Obsidian files. Robocopy was promptly completed and all files were restored; if there are any remaining conflicts, please contact **Julian Cabiya or Eli(se) Davidson** for additional assistance.

We learned quite a few things with this issue:

- The 900+ digital files of the collection need to be stored in the Cloud due to the disk space available (i.e., C:\ or D:\)
 - **Fix:** The audio/video files are stored in a folder titled “VWS Digitization” in **SharePoint** found the Butler University Libraries-Special Collections private channel: [Documents/Special Collections/Projects/VWS Digitization³](#)
 - The folder “**EMiller-2020_Digitization**” is the digitized effort from Evan Miller, completed and uploaded to Google Drive in 2020.
 - The “**EDavidson-2024-2026_Digitization**” folder is the digitized effort from Eli(se) Davidson, completed and uploaded to OneDrive; migrated to SharePoint as of April 2026 with the help of **Julian Cabiya**.
 - **Result:** .mp3/4 files will not display, showing the response: “[file name] could not be found” -- DO NOT CLICK! Clicking on the link will create a new, empty file of the same name and can cause conflicts.

³ The levels of access to this directory will have to be considered when determining the next steps in what the repository looks like.

- **NOTE:** This is an issue that needs to be addressed IMMEDIATELY.
 - In a perfect world, the AV digitized files would be in the same folder with **.obsidian** and the other rendered markdown media files, AKA within the **vault** (created at **C:\Users\"NAME"\Documents\OBSIDIANBACKUP\"YYYY-MM-DD"**). BUT this has issues; our team cannot access the collection if it is located in the User profile locally hosted in the Digital Lab—**how do we address both issues?**